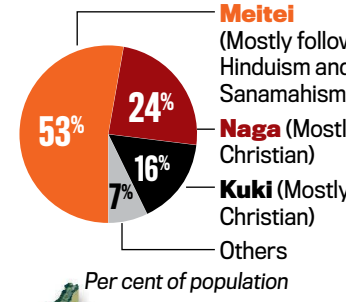
The spectre of ethnic conflict returned to haunt Manipur on May 3 when a solidarity march by the All Tribal Students' Union of Manipur (ATSUM) turned violent. Reports of killings, rioting and destruction of property soon emerged from several districts, including Imphal East, Imphal West, Kakching, Thoubal, Kangpokpi, Tengnoupal and Jiribam, besides Churachandpur. The first six districts are dominated by the Meitei community while mostly Kuki tribes live in the other three. The army and Assam Rifles carried out flag marches, internet services were suspended, curfew imposed and nearly 15,000 people from affected areas were evacuated to relief camps. The government claims 60 people were killed and over 200 injured; unofficial estimates of the toll are much higher.

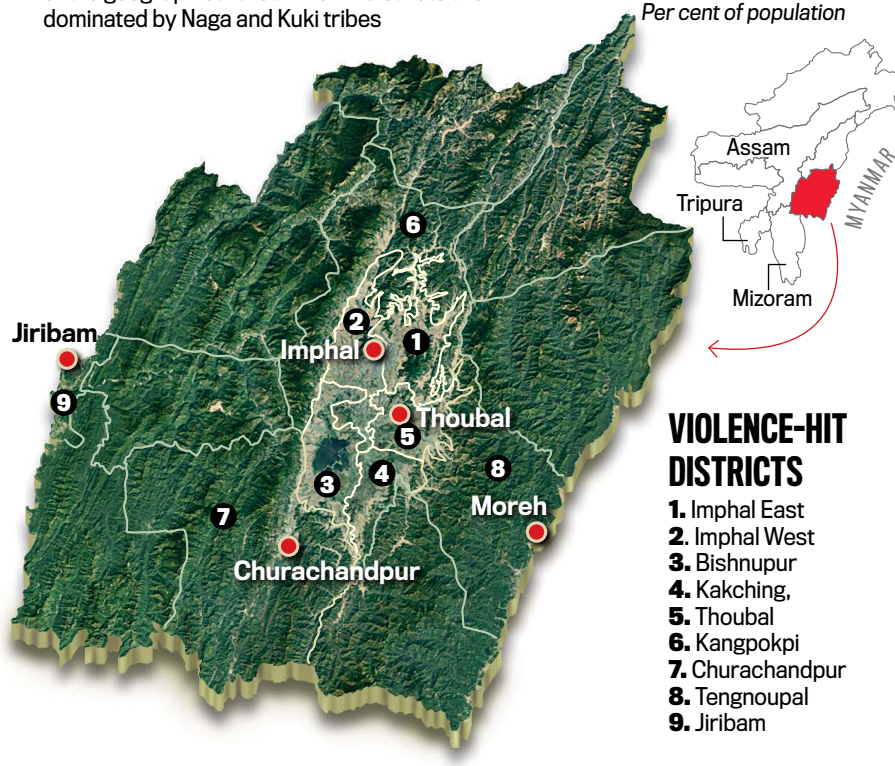
The tribal solidarity march was being held to voice opposition to a Manipur High Court order of April 14 that asked the state government to send a recommendation to the Centre for inclusion of the Meitei community in the state list of Scheduled Tribes (ST). The order—later held by the Supreme Court to be beyond the remit of the high court to issue—reignited historical tensions between Meiteis, mostly resident in the saucer-shaped Imphal valley, and the state's hill tribes, primarily Nagas and Kukis.

Unrest between Meiteis and Kukis had anyway been brewing from the beginning of this year. As it precipitated into a full-blown bloodbath, the political crisis deepened for Chief Minister N. Biren Singh, with vociferous demands for his removal coming from some of his own colleagues in the BJP. Paolienlal Haokip, party MLA from Saikot and a Kuki leader, accuses Biren, a Meitei, of being anti-Kuki—a charge naturally rejected by the CM, who has survived past moves against him due to backing from the national leadership. Last month, about a dozen BJP MLAs, mostly Kukis, were in Delhi to press for a change of the CM or at least a rejig in the state cabinet.

THE ETHNIC DIVIDE

Of the 60 assembly constituencies in Manipur, 40 seats are in the valley areas which comprise six districts—Imphal East, Imphal West, Thoubal, Bishnupur, Kakching and Kangkopi. The remaining 20 seats are spread over the other 10 districts. The valley districts, dominated by the Meitei community, account for just over 11 per cent of the geographical area. The hill districts are dominated by Naga and Kuki tribes





VIOLENCE-HIT DISTRICTS

1. Imphal East
2. Imphal West
3. Bishnupur
4. Kakching,
5. Thoubal
6. Kangpokpi
7. Churachandpur
8. Tengnoupal
9. Jiribam

Geographically, Manipur can be divided into the Imphal valley and the hill areas. Of Manipur's 60 assembly constituencies, 40 are packed into the six districts of the densely-populated valley—Imphal East and West, Thoubal, Bishnupur, Kakching and Kangpokpi. The remaining 20 are spread over the other 10 districts. The valley accounts for just over 11 per cent of Manipur's geographical area, but is home to 57 per cent of the state's total population of 2.8 million (2011 Census)—the predominantly Hindu Meitei community being the most numerous and emblematic among them. The hill districts, with over 88 per cent of the land, host just 43 per cent of the population. Kukis to the southwest, Nagas drawing the rest of the circle (*see map*)—and both with a strong Christian imprint. It's a social geography that already contains all the ingredients for ethno-religious rivalry.

No wonder the tripartite conflict has a long history. The tribes claim the valley people have cornered developmental works through political dominance, while Meiteis allege they are increasingly getting marginalised, with their population down to 44 per cent in the 2011 Census from 59 per cent in 1951. They also cannot buy land in hill areas (where tribals have exclusive rights).

A recent plea before the Manipur HC by the Meitei Tribe Union argued that the community was recognised as a tribe before the merger of the princely state of Manipur with the Union of India in 1949, but lost the identity later. Only restoration of that badge will help "preserve" the community, and save its "ancestral land, tradition, culture and language", it argued. Tribal bodies see this as a ploy by Meiteis to take control